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SCHOOLS, TEACHERS, AND TEACHER EDUCATORS: EDUCATION THROUGH THE DISRUPTION OF WHITE SUPREMACY

Abstract

This article examines the entrenchment White Supremacy in the American educational system, and the implications of these beliefs on teacher education and teacher preparation. Efforts at Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Social Justice have multiple barriers to pierce to create significant change. Schools are a reproduction of larger society and normalized White Supremacy. In this article, I offer a brief historical analysis of the underlying systems that shape the curriculum, standards, and instruction that reproduce White Supremacy in K-12 U.S. schools and offer opportunities for resistance, change, and...disruption.

Keywords: *White supremacy, K-12 education, teacher education, culturally sustaining pedagogy, curriculum and power*

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Teaching is a political act. I first recognized my role as a political agent in education when I attended my first conference for Social Studies educators as a first-year faculty member of a Predominantly White Institutions of Higher Education. In between a conference session, I went to introduce myself to the speaker who was a cis-White Male, former high school Social Studies Teacher and now Professor at Research I Institution. His session focused on Methods of Instruction for Secondary Social Studies Teacher Candidates (Students who are education majors and will be teachers in Social Studies classes for middle and high schools). I was in my first semester of teaching Social Studies Methods for Adolescence Education, and I had a lot of questions. As I approached the speaker, he did not see me. He couldn't see me. Because surrounding him, and hiding me, were about eight to ten other tall (e.g. over 5 feet), white, Cis-gender males, who were also former high school Social Studies teachers (and former coaches). I literally and figuratively couldn't be seen or heard. I carried that feeling throughout the whole conference. There really was not a space for me. I saw occasional people of color, but they had their peers.

When I spoke with one of my White mentors, she encouraged me to find other organizations to find my place and where they would value what I brought. With respect to my mentor, this was a very White answer. It is easy to create another space or enter in other spaces when you have never been excluded from a space. It is easy for White people to imagine that there will always be another place to go. For me, the answer was not to seek another space, but to learn the ways of the current space…and then disrupt it.

The choices teachers, instructors, professors make to include, or exclude, topics in their instruction are political acts. The way I choose to show up for my students, and the way I choose to teach and work with future social studies educators is intentional. To label something in history as "Manifest Destiny" instead of describing it as examples of "genocide", "colonization", or "white supremacy" excuses the erasure and devastation of Indigenous land, cultures, and rights. In order to examine what we are supposed to be teaching and what we are expected to be teaching, it is important to define the words and phrases we are using. In order to demonstrate how K-12 public schools continue to uphold systems of white supremacy, it's important to identify what White Supremacy is.

> What does "White" mean? Congressional approval of the Naturalization Act of 1790 involved the use of the term "White." The Naturalization Act excluded from citizenship all non-Whites, such as Native Americans, who were considered domestic foreigners and, therefore, ineligible for citizenship. The legislation specifically stated that citizenship would be granted only to a "free White person."[1]

"White" has been established as the norm…as the goal. People of color are often alerted to their "otherness" early in their lives that they are not White. (Note: This is usually done during childhood and usually at school). The positioning and understanding of being "othered: is significant because it is one of the steps that is necessary to take because it begins the process

[1] Joel Spring, *Deculturalization and the Struggle for Equality: A Brief History of the Education of Dominated Cultures in the United States*, 9th ed. (Routledge, 2022), 2.

of assimilation. Speaking from experience, the otherness will suffocate you if you do not begin to assimilate.

It (assimilation) is the first introduction to the system of White supremacy and the way in which it encompasses schools and educational opportunities. Allen and Liou[2] provide the following explanation of White supremacy as a social system:

> In describing White supremacy as a social system, we are referring to a larger society that, despite times of what may seem like racial progress (e.g., the Civil Rights Era or Reconstruction), is fundamentally arranged to ensure that Whites remain in control of society, as they work to unjustly and immorally construct a higher social status over people of color.[3]

Allen and Liou's description of White supremacy as a social system provides context for why educational initiatives aimed at providing equity are often not enough.[4] The ways in which people of color are encouraged to become more White adjacent. While the school system itself is powerful in erasing culture, it is aided by the students, teachers, and administrators in the school who will continue to enforce White supremacy practices. Administrators will have a difficult time talking to parents who may not speak the same language or may be working during times when the administrator wants to meet. Teachers may not be familiar with the cultural practices of their students and may not be able to accommodate their needs. But nothing, I mean, nothing reinforces White supremacy practices like peer pressure in a K-12 public school. It may begin during attendance with the name that is mispronounced or weird. It will then move to the lunchroom where the smell of curry will cause your classmates to inquire if you are eating a dirty diaper for lunch. Or, it might move to the reading group where students who are fluent in multiple languages and knowledgeable about oral histories are positioned as deficient. They will engage in literacy instruction that values printed literacy and culturally neutral stories. To identify words and sounds such as box, fox, and socks successfully will be the markers of success and reading achievement. The following sections examine how schools are reproductions of society, and by extension, White Supremacy, ways to disrupt the status quo, and ways in which the field of K-12 education is still struggling with aligning with White Supremacy.

Schools as Reproductions of Society

What is the purpose of schooling? Depending on who is asked, there are varied responses for the purpose of schooling. We know that K-12 schools were created to replicate White Supremacy. Historically, there have been clear efforts to strip the culture, histories, and languages of Native Americans, Africans, Latinos, and Asians- across all diasporas.[5] For Native Americans and Indigenous groups this has been true since Captain Richard Henry Pratt invaded Rosebud Reservation in September 1879. For African Americans, this has been true since the first enslaved Africans were ripped of their language, their identities, and their humanities. The pattern is the same; to remove the differences that are positioned as deficits

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[2] Ricky L. Allen and Daniel D. Liou, "Managing Whiteness: The Call for Educational Leadership to Breach the Contractual Expectations of White Supremacy," *Urban Education* 54, no. 5 (2018): 677–705, https://doi.org/10.1177/004208591878381.

[3] Derrick Bell, *Faces at the Bottom of the Well* (Basic Books, 1992), 678.

[4] Allen and Liou, "Managing Whiteness"

[5] Django Paris and Samy Alim, eds., *Culturally Sustaining Pedagogies: Teaching and Learning for Justice in a Changing World* (Teachers College Press, 2016); Joel Spring, *Deculturalization and the Struggle for Equality: A Brief History of the Education of Dominated Cultures in the United States*, 9th ed. (Routledge, 2022).

from those that are "othered". Schools were places for successes to occur if the "others" could fall in line in ways that help them assimilate.

The result is what we have today. Schools (and by extension, Institutions of Higher Education) have normalized the system of White Supremacy. Moreover, schools are taken for granted as the most effective and "equitable" avenues to success. For many immigrants and historically underrepresented communities, schools offer a chance at the "American Dream". Refugees and immigrants seek American lives out as a promise of something better or something more-better lives, more opportunities, more success.

> In the context of the United States and other nation-states living out the legacies of genocide, land theft, enslavement, and various forms of colonialism…The purpose of state-sanctioned schooling has been to forward the largely assimilationist and often violent White imperial protect, with students and families being asked to lost or deny their languages, literacies, cultures, and histories in order to achieve in schools.[6]

State-sanctioned schooling highlights curriculum and standards as the way to achieve success through learning outcomes. It is a pattern that is easily recognized by most in educational spaces (K-12 schooling or Institutes of Higher Education). Broadly speaking, a standard curriculum has four principles: *defining objectives, identifying experiences, organizing experiences, evaluating effectiveness.*[7] However, a closer examination of curriculum reveals multiple forms of curriculum: *explicit, implicit, and null.*[8] The explicit curriculum is the traditional curriculum- the one that includes the explained learning outcomes and includes the objectives (i.e. lesson plans or syllabus), experiences (instructional activities), and evaluations (assessments and finals). The implicit curriculum is the curriculum that learners pick up from their schooling and learning experiences such as the unspoken behaviors, values, and traditions-including implied understandings about race, class, gender, and sexuality. The null curriculum refers to the information that is removed or not acknowledged. It is the continued threat that pervades schools as books are removed from libraries and information is removed from the explicit curriculum. The three forms of curriculum work in tandem, when unchallenged, to replicate White supremacy in schools and in learners. The three forms of curriculum are enacted so that the purpose of schooling reflects the power structures of society. For this to shift, educators need to disrupt the narrative of White Supremacy.

Disrupting the Narrative of White Supremacy

In order to disrupt the status quo, it's important to consider in what ways educator perspectives differ from the status quo. When teaching future educators, my first step in this endeavor is to try to find out why they want to teach. What led them to seek a degree in education? Why work with youth instead of teaching in a museum or studying history? For many students, a degree in social studies education is partly a response to enjoying history and partly a response to a positive high school teacher. For many social studies teachers, the love of history is tied to an era of American exceptionalism and moral correctness. The Revolutionary War and World War II often feature broadly in terms of courses taken and history shared. Often this shared history is a result of the null curriculum. The love of the Revolutionary War provides an explicit curriculum that often highlights the heroic fighting with Washington

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[6] Paris and Alim, *Culturally Sustaining Pedagogies, 1.*

[7] Ralph Tyler, *Basic Principles of Curriculum and Instruction* (University of Chicago Press, 1969).

[8] Elliot Eisner, *The Educational Imagination* (Pearson, 2002).

Crossing the Delaware and the culminating inspiration of the signing of the Declaration of Independence. The implicit curriculum encourages students to not ask about why women and enslaved African Americans were not part of the document, or even in the room. Students' love of World War II often stems from the explicit curriculum highlighting the fighting of the Nazis, the defeat of Hitler, the defeat of fascist…at the expense of the null curriculum that concealed the horrors of California's Japanese Internment Camps and the behind-the-scenes stories of the creation of the Atom Bomb.

The danger in forgetting and ignoring history is that it repeats itself. As of writing of this manuscript, two unelected members of the current Presidential Administration have performed the Nazi Salute. Since the 2024 election, Neo-Nazis have marched in Ohio and Alabama and disrupted a performance of the Diary of Anne Frank in Michigan. To disrupt the status quo, teacher educators need to not only know the null curriculum but move it to the explicit curriculum. My role as a social studies teacher educator is to help future social studies teachers understand that explicit curriculum that highlights World War II learning standards is now a living document. To do this, I bring in current news articles from a variety of sources that are well-researched and respected. Additionally, current media sources used during instructional activities offer an opportunity to engage in discussions about critical media literacy. Using tools such as Project Look Sharp or Allsides Media Bias Chart provide tools for readers to examine updated information through a critical media lens.

Disruption requires multiple voices and multiple stories. To fully combat White supremacy, the explicit curriculum must promote perspectives from voices that White supremacy seeks to silence. Organizations like the American Library Association and We Need Diverse Books fight against censorship and book banning but encourage a wide variety of voices for learners at every age range and reading level. From picture books to young adult literature, stories BIPOC (Black, Indigenous, People of Color) and LGBTQIA+ (Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Queer, Intersex, and Asexual+) authors are available for learners of all ages. Teacher candidates in my Social Studies Methods courses are required to read the truthful histories from African American, Asian Americans, Latino Americans, Native Americans, and Members of the LGBTQIA+ community.[9] After requiring my future teachers to read these histories, they are then asked to compare and contrast the explicit curriculum with the hidden histories from the books that they have read. Inevitably, there is a recognition that there is more to the story and that there is always more to learn and more stories to hear. While not every future teacher is going to connect to the disruption and engage in this approach in their own classrooms. However, they have taken the two steps: they now know the truth and I've asked them to find where that truth was hiding. Perhaps it will be part of a conversation with a family member or friend, or perhaps it will be a choice to research in a future classroom, and perhaps it will be a part of the lecture and, eventually, learned by the next generation of teachers, activists, and leaders.

A significant part of the successful disruption includes Culturally Sustaining Pedagogy (CSP).[10] CSP provides the foundation for pedagogies that encourage additive, rather than

[9] Ronald Takaki, *A Different Mirror for Young People: A History of Multicultural America*, adapted by Rebecca Stefoff (Seven Stories Press, 2012); Michael Bronski, *A Queer History of the United States for Young People*, adapted by Richie Chevat (Beacon Press, 2019); Roxanne Dunbar-Ortiz, *An Indigenous Peoples' History of the United States for Young People,* adapted by Jean Mendoza and Debbie Reese (Beacon Press, 2019); Margarita Engle, *Dreams from Many Rivers: A Hispanic History of the United States Told in Poems* (Atheneum Books for Young Readers, 2019).; Jason Reynolds and Ibram X. Kendi, *Stamped: Racism, Antiracism, and You* (Little, Brown Books for Young Readers, 2020).

[10] Paris and Alim, *Culturally Sustaining Pedagogies.*

subtractive, culturally enriching strengths. As aforementioned, schooling continues to find ways to erase students' linguistic and cultural histories in many of our schools in the United States. In this approach, schooling is not only multicultural and multilingual, but encourages pluralism in classrooms (at all levels). This type of pluralism discourages a deficit model of learning and provides opportunities for positive social engagement and interaction, rather than an erasure of the "other". The instructor within this pedagogical approach must also hold high expectations for students but understand and acknowledge the inequities that affect their success in classrooms that reflect White supremacy. Educators who are able to navigate CSP successfully will investigate, learn, honor, and engage heritage and cultural practices so that they can identify ways to create opportunities for learning that provide voice, agency, and power. For instance, educators teaching in a computer science course may not envision that there is relevance for cultural connections outside of the learning objectives associated with computation, information, and automation. However, current research by Black women scholars in the field yields information regarding bias and inequity in algorithms and how they are implemented. This may lead to empowering Black female coders to find authentic solutions for needs within the community. Disrupting White supremacy means acknowledging that the skill and ability levels are not different among races, classes, and gender- opportunity is the biggest difference. Educators committed to disruption will find ways to provide the opportunities.

Reproduction of White Supremacy

As a teacher educator, I am constantly reproducing White supremacy in order to ensure that my teacher candidates are able to attain certification according to the New York State Education Department. In order for teacher candidates to be successful and remain in their positions, they must complete the certification requirements as approved by each state. New York State has earned the reputation for the most rigorous requirements; these requirements are accepted readily at each of the 49 other states.

Teacher candidates who are eligible for teacher certification must also pay for and pass two certification tests, in addition to additional hidden costs such as fingerprinting and traveling expenses for student teaching. Historically, teaching as a profession has appealed to the established middle class. As a result, teacher candidates are often from white middle class families and are able to afford many of the hidden costs associated with teacher education programs. In order to address these inequities, more programs need to be available to support students from lower income families and backgrounds and BIPOC students. While these programs are available in limited forms, they often reproduce White supremacy by supporting students of color to achieve through replicating the behaviors and actions of White students and established White practices. There are no culturally sustaining practices that are part of the teacher certification process. Examinations are not multilingual or multicultural. The process of becoming certified assumes that teacher candidates have the social, cultural, and financial capital to graduate from an undergraduate program, navigate the process for searching for and applying to jobs, identify and applying for the correct Graduate Program to obtain their permanent certification and sustain themselves with a living expenses before they receive their first full-time job. For students of color, this process becomes more difficult when schools and districts are not prepared to work with culturally diverse teacher candidates. In addition to not having professional connections, BIPOC teacher candidates may experience microaggressions and misunderstandings about professional hair and dress.

There have been numerous times that a White cooperating teacher who hosted a Black teacher candidate made a comment to me in which they were concerned about their teacher candidate's hair or dress.[11] However, in instances of "professional dress", we are stuck at a proverbial fork in the road of White supremacy. In this case, the teacher candidate's professional clothes were older and worn, and the candidate did not have the funds for new clothes. In order to continue to support our students from lower income backgrounds, we have provided gently used professional clothes for teacher candidates to wear to their student teaching experiences and job opportunities. However, this reinforces the White practices that are expected. Could we encourage our teacher candidates to dress casually, but appropriately, if they do not have the financial means? Should we encourage teacher candidates from multiple backgrounds to dress culturally appropriately? The CROWN (Create a Respectful World for Natural Hair) Act of 2021 is a federal law, for now, that will protect individuals from underrepresented backgrounds. However, the law cannot necessarily protect individuals from comments and/or microaggressions.

Education, as a field, is a bastion of White supremacy. Ironically, the threat of dissolving the Department of Education would not be as scary if it was not another form of White Supremacy. Destroying the Department of Education would affect historically marginalized groups such as students with disabilities and students from lower socioeconomic backgrounds. While it does not emphasize race, evidence suggests that this action would disproportionately affect students of color. Moreover, future generations of communities of color will be affected by the lack of access to institutions of higher education due to lack of opportunities and funding. While I recognize that there are practices of White supremacy that provide a barrier to potential teachers from underrepresented communities, I also recognize that I need to help provide a bridge for more future disruptors. While I need to provide access to the practices of White supremacy, I also have a commitment to provide an education to my teacher candidates and future educators.

Looking Ahead

November 2024 demonstrated that people have short memories. Early 2025 reminded us of the importance of not only studying history but understanding and having the ability to recognize when the dangers have returned. Culturally, historically, and politically we are at a crossroads. Democracy is messy and it is fragile. In order for it to thrive, a democratic society requires educated, passionate, and ethical citizens. Education has always been crucial to a democracy-it is the reason autocrats try to destroy education. For this reason, I look to the past to help contextualize the future.

On October 16, 1963, James Baldwin delivered *A Talk to Teachers* to a group of teachers in New York City. Against the backdrop of anti-black violence and in the middle of the Civil Rights Movement, Baldwin addressed how teachers have a responsibility to confront injustice in the classroom, especially in the aftermath of the Murder of Emmett Till, the Bombing of the 16th Street Baptist Church, and the March on Washington. I have included his words because I could not express it any better:

> Let's begin by saying that we are living through a very dangerous time. Everyone in this room is in one way or another aware of that. We are in a revolutionary situation, no matter how unpopular that word has become in this country. The society in which

[11] There was nothing wrong with the teacher candidate's hair. The style was natural and culturally appropriate.

> we live is desperately menaced, not by Khrushchev, but from within. To any citizen of this country who figures himself as responsible — and particularly those of you who deal with the minds and hearts of young people — must be prepared to "go for broke." Or to put it another way, you must understand that in the attempt to correct so many generations of bad faith and cruelty, when it is operating not only in the classroom but in society, you will meet the most fantastic, the most brutal, and the most determined resistance. There is no point in pretending that this won't happen.[12]

As clairvoyant and ever relevant as Baldwin is, his call to teachers is equally important. It is not a time to be neutral. It is time to counteract the hidden curriculum and teach the truth to the null curriculum.

The original purpose of school was to help students contribute to the status quo. Students who went to school and were successful would be able to engage in practices that replicate White supremacy. For the past 20-30 years, though, teachers and students have engaged in critical practices that provide opportunities beyond the explicit curriculum and create spaces and opportunities for those who will challenge the status quo. This type of schooling is powerful and it is working. It is working so well that on January 29, 2025, an Executive Order from the White House was issued that focused on "Ending Radical Indoctrination in K-12 Schooling."[13] This Executive Order was simply a larger and louder culmination of continued censorship and banning of the truth in history. But it also reveals a larger truth-the answer to the original question. The purpose of school is replication. What is the purpose of Education? Liberation.

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[12] James Baldwin, *A Talk to Teachers* (1963), University of Washington, par.1, https://faculty.washington.edu/joyann/EDLSP549Beadie_Williamson/Baldwin.pdf.

[13] The White House, "Ending Radical Indoctrination in K-12 Schooling," The White House, January 29, 2025, https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/01/ending-radical-indoctrination-in-k-12-schooling/.